

bombing on a significant scale. This brought forth vigorous protests from the US government, which was inclined to head for the moral high ground as examples of the bombing of civilians multiplied. Secretary of State Cordell Hull said of the bombing of Barcelona: "No theory of war can justify such conduct." And in June 1938, the Senate passed a resolution

condemning "the inhuman bombing of civilian populations." Yet the Roosevelt administration also sought increased funds for the American long-range bomber force, reasoning that the best way to stop an enemy from bombing your cities was to threaten credibly to flatten his in reprisal.

The other answer to the threat of bombing was to prepare air defenses to block an attack and civil defense to limit casualties. The concept of air defense was not popular with air commanders committed to war-winning strategic bombing – it was hard for them to argue that their bombers would "always get through" without

accepting that enemy bombers would inevitably do the same. But the Germans had found in Spain just how vulnerable bombers would actually be – every bombing raid needed a fighter escort. In Britain, the government overruled the RAF and, in the second half of the 1930s, insisted on giving high priority to building fighters and preparing a coordinated air-defense system.

Defensive measures

One reason Douhet had given for believing that bombers could not be stopped was that their raids would come as a surprise, striking before fighters could be scrambled to intercept them. But in the 1930s, forms of radar were being developed and refined in all advanced countries – though not all were being applied to air defense – along with primitive IFF (Identification Friend or Foe) systems that allowed ground

MONSTER EAR TRUMPETS

Emperor Hirohito inspects the huge trumpetlike aircraft detectors/audible rangefinders that were part of the air defense in Japan, and other countries, in 1935. Designed to pick up the low rumble of approaching enemy aircraft, they worked in conjunction with antiaircraft guns, visible on the right.

